COMPETITIVE ASSESSMENT: BRIEF

Serverless Inference Assessment

Baseten, DeepInfra, and Nebius Token Factory, with implications for Akamai Cloud

PREPARED BY
Chris McConnell

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0. Summary

Serverless inference landscape: Baseten, DeepInfra, Nebius Token Factory. This brief answers each assessment deliverable in the order asked. The companion full report, `serverless-inference-assessment-full-report-chris-mcconnell.pdf`, holds the evidence, citations, method, and extended tables; section numbers in this brief match it (the full report's section 5 is its evidence appendix). Facts dated 2026-09-28, except probe captures (2026-09-29) and pages that block scripted clients, read in a browser on 2026-09-29.

Key insights

> **The engine layer is commoditized: all 3 competitors serve on open engines, and all 3 run vLLM.**
>
> - Baseten and DeepInfra run vLLM, SGLang, TensorRT-LLM, and NVIDIA Dynamo; Nebius runs vLLM in production. All sit behind an OpenAI-compatible API, and Akamai's LKE stack already offers vLLM and NVIDIA Dynamo.
> - Differentiation sits in what is disclosed, where requests land, and how capacity is priced.

> **Marketing outruns contracts: Baseten markets 99.99% uptime against a 99.9% SLA.**
>
> - DeepInfra markets "reliable" with no SLA.
> - Nebius markets sub-second TTFT that third-party data does not show on its serverless tier.

> **None of the 3 places GPUs by user geography.**
>
> - DeepInfra answers from one /24 on its own network in the US.
> - Nebius answers from a single address on its own network in NL.
> - Baseten rents Google's front end, then hops to whichever cloud has capacity.

> **Akamai's opening is a published serving contract plus geography-aware routing, but the edge advantage is not automatic: 164 ms to first byte against 106 ms for Baseten.**
>
> - From one US vantage point, a minimal request to `api.linode.com` returns its first byte in 164 ms, against 106 ms for Baseten's Google front end and 465 ms for Nebius.

Competitor snapshot

	Baseten	DeepInfra	Nebius Token Factory
Sells	Inference engineering depth and multi-cloud capacity	Lowest list price on owned GPUs	Owned EU capacity, fine-tune and serve
Buyer	ML platform lead at an AI-native scale-up	Developer optimizing cost per token	Regulated or EU enterprise
Strength	Fastest shared-API TTFT (0.19 s, gpt-oss-120b); deepest engine controls	Priced prefix caching, three service tiers, fullest public API spec	99.9% SLA on dedicated; EU residency on dedicated
Exploitable gap	99.99% marketed versus 99.9% contracted; 8 major incidents in 90 days	No SLA, no EU region, 31 of 102 models with undeclared precision	Serverless has no region guarantee; OpenRouter uptime 91 to 97%

Recommendations for Akamai

1. **Publish a serving contract per model** (precision, served context, engine, TTFT target at a stated concurrency, deprecation notice) and a 99.9% SLA on the serverless tier from launch.
2. **Make routing geography the product**: OpenAI-compatible gateway at the edge, region pinning for residency, KV-aware routing, and priced prefix caching compatible with DeepInfra's fields.
3. **Size the catalog to the RTX PRO 6000 fleet**, sell service tiers instead of engine knobs, price mid-pack rather than at parity, and offer an export path to LKE.

Detail in section 4A. Evidence base: unauthenticated probes of each provider's API, DNS, origin ASN, status page, and OpenAPI spec; vendor documentation, contracts, and pricing pages (203 cited URLs checked on 2026-09-29); third-party benchmarks used with stated caveats.

1. Product Positioning & Messaging Audit

1.1 Market narrative

Vector	Baseten	DeepInfra	Nebius Token Factory
Tagline	"Inference is everything"	"AI Inference: FAST, SIMPLE, RELIABLE, LOW-COST"	"Run open models at production scale"
Core frame	Inference engineering company: runtime, control plane (Truss, environments), and capacity brokered across 18 clouds and 87 clusters	Price and ownership company: owned GPUs in nine colocation sites, "from GPU hardware to API layer"	Vertically integrated neocloud: inference layer on Nebius-owned data centers, fine-tune and serve on one platform
Lead product	Dedicated Inference per GPU-minute; per-token Model APIs added May 2025	Serverless per-token APIs	Serverless per-token plus Dedicated Endpoints (GA 2026-02-26)
Proof points	Named logos (Notion, Cursor, Writer), day-0 launches	Price tables, "close to five trillion tokens a week", OpenRouter supply share	Prosus "up to 26x cost reductions", Revolut, Sword Health
Where it is thin	"Cross-cloud high availability", yet 17 of 35 incidents in 90 days name a single cluster, region, cloud, or upstream	"Reliable" with no SLA; terms promise "commercially reasonable efforts"	"Production scale" serverless carries "no region guarantee"; the 99.9% SLA covers dedicated only

Baseten sells engineering depth, DeepInfra sells unit price, Nebius sells owned capacity and European residency. None sells proximity to the end user, the vector an edge network can own.

1.2 Target personas

Dimension	Baseten	DeepInfra	Nebius Token Factory
Economic buyer	VP Engineering or Head of ML Platform at an AI-native scale-up with revenue tied to latency	Founder or lead engineer at a token-volume product (agents, chat, aggregators)	Head of AI Platform or CTO at a European or regulated enterprise
Hands-on user	ML engineer comfortable with Truss and engine configuration	Application developer who swaps a base URL in the OpenAI SDK	Application developer (serverless); platform engineer (dedicated, post-training)
Buying trigger	Latency SLO on a custom or fine-tuned model	Bill shock on a closed-model API	Data residency mandate; fine-tune and serve on one platform
Deal blocker to exploit	Price: H100 $6.50/h, B200 $9.98/h list	No SLA, no EU region, no custom containers on serverless	Serverless is EU-anchored with no region guarantee

1.3 Claims versus reality

Claim	Baseten	DeepInfra	Nebius
"Instant" cold starts	**Partially supported.** "Blazing-fast cold starts", but the cold-start docs give no latency figure; about 10 s for small cached models, unquantified for 70B+; wake-up minutes billed	**Not claimed.** Warm shared pool; contention becomes a 429 or a Flex wait of up to 10 minutes instead of a cold start	**Unsupported for serverless.** Claim is "sub-second responses for interactive agents" (Fast flavor), but six serverless `-fast` SKUs were removed in June; holds only on dedicated endpoints with min replicas above zero
"99.99% availability"	**Unsupported.** Marketed 99.99%, contracted 99.9% with credits capped at 40%. Model APIs logged 299 major-incident minutes in 90 days against a 13 minute 99.99% budget	**Not claimed numerically.** No SLA; single-model outages of 8 h and 6 h in July with no remedy	**Partially supported.** 99.9% SLA on dedicated only, and only under contract; OpenRouter 30-day serverless uptime 91.4% to 96.9%
"Sub-second TTFT"	**Supported on TTFT, not on throughput.** Claim is "fastest runtime available": 0.19 s on gpt-oss-120b, fastest of the three; mid-pack on throughput (10 of 18)	**Holds on average, fails at the tail.** 0.69 s on gpt-oss-120b; p99 17 s in a paired test	**Unsupported.** 0.94 s on gpt-oss-120b, 0.99 to 2.33 s on reasoning models; 217 ms edge TTFB from US Central before inference starts

TTFT figures are Artificial Analysis (10k-token input; reasoning-model figures include thinking time, so they are an upper bound) and a 600-request paired test; edge TTFB is llmlatency.dev. Verbatim claims, contract text, and incident data: full report 1.3.

2. Technical Architecture & Engine Mechanics

2.1 Model comparison and availability

Measure	Baseten	DeepInfra	Nebius Token Factory
Serverless catalog	11 Model API slugs (DeepSeek V4, GLM 5.x, Kimi K3, Nemotron 3 Ultra, gpt-oss-120b); Llama and Qwen only in the deployable library	102 active text models, 385 entries across all modalities; 26 partner-proxied models, mostly closed (Claude, Gemini, Qwen Max, Seed)	About 25 text models after 21 SKUs were removed in three months; 43 dedicated templates
Latest models	Day-0: DeepSeek V4 Pro 0813 (2026-08-13), Kimi K3 (2026-07-27), GLM-5.3	Hy4-preview (2026-09-25), MiMo V2.6 (2026-09-22), DeepSeek V4.1 Flash (2026-09-10)	Day-one: Kimi K3, GLM-5.2, MiniMax M3, Nemotron 3 Ultra
Deprecation	Six Model APIs retired with 12 days notice	At least one week notice; requests silently forwarded to a replacement model	No automatic reroute
Precision disclosure	User-selected per deployment	Per model; 31 of 102 active text models undeclared	Per template flavor, plus tokens/s per flavor
How models are marketed	Day-0 launch speed and named logos; "Fast" SKUs at 1.5x price	Price and breadth; Priority and Flex badges	Curated frontier models on owned capacity
Customer use cases named	Code completion (Cursor, Zed), clinical documentation (Abridge), voice and TTS (Speechify)	Agent platforms, OpenRouter supply, long-horizon coding	Coding agents, AI search, fraud and risk (Revolut), digital health (Sword Health)

All three carry the current frontier open-weight families (DeepSeek V4, Kimi K3, GLM 5.x) and announce day-0 or day-one launches. They differ in breadth (DeepInfra) and in catalog stability (Nebius removed 21 SKUs; DeepInfra redirects silently).

2.2 Execution engines and runtimes

	Baseten	DeepInfra	Nebius
Engines in production	TensorRT-LLM (Engine Builder), vLLM and SGLang (BIS-LLM), NVIDIA Dynamo; custom containers	vLLM for most of the catalog, SGLang, TensorRT-LLM, Dynamo	vLLM; TensorRT-LLM in a proof of concept; LMCache for long context
Proprietary layer	Custom C++ gRPC server replacing Triton; BEI embeddings	Maintained forks of vLLM, TensorRT-LLM, SGLang, Dynamo	Cache-aware router; EAGLE-3 speculator training
Batching exposed to the developer	Engine knobs on dedicated: `max_batch_size` (default 256), `max_num_tokens`, scheduler policy, chunked prefill	None on serverless; sold as tiers: Flex 0.8x (bounded wait), Priority 1.5x, `fail_fast`	None on serverless; "Fast" flavor means smaller batches and more compute

All three serve on engines built on continuous (in-flight) batching; none uses static batching on shared tiers. The operating point between throughput and per-request speed is the product decision. Baseten exposes it as configuration, DeepInfra and Nebius sell it as a price tier. TGI, named in the brief, is no longer live: Hugging Face

archived it on 2026-03-21, and none of the three uses it for managed serving. Full detail and lineage diagram: full report 2.2.

2.3 Memory and KV cache management

Technique	Baseten	DeepInfra	Nebius
Paged KV cache (PagedAttention)	Documented, with configuration keys and host offload	Implied by its vLLM and TensorRT-LLM forks	Implied by vLLM
Prefix caching	Documented; Model APIs bill cached input at about 10% of input; `x-session-affinity` keeps a session on one replica	Documented and priced: cache reads on 51 of 102 models, explicit TTL of 5 minutes or 1 hour	No cached-input price; `cached_tokens` returned; feature request "In Review"
KV-aware routing	Dynamo router, Enterprise plan only	Dynamo (engineering blog)	Custom cache-aware router: 95% cache hit versus 62% under Kubernetes ClusterIP
Speculative decoding	Eagle, MTP, NGram by configuration	Not documented	Used by the Fast flavor; zero data retention disables it
Quantization	FP8; FP4 on B200	FP4 "all-in"; served context can drop	FP8 default; FP4 and INT4 for some models

DeepInfra has turned the KV cache into a priced, programmable resource. Nebius couples a privacy setting to a performance feature, so regulated buyers choose between residency and speed.

2.4 Routing and multi-region topology

Provider	Ingress (probe captures)	Region control	TTFB p50, US vantage
Baseten	Google global front end, then a hop to a GPU in one of 18 clouds	`us` or `eu` pinning	106 ms
DeepInfra	14 addresses in one /24 on its own network (AS16581), US	None; eight US sites plus Toronto	112 ms
Nebius	One NL-registered address on its own network (AS214415)	Serverless "no region guarantee"; dedicated region by contract	465 ms
Akamai Cloud (baseline)	`api.linode.com` on the Akamai edge	33 core regions; RTX PRO 6000 in 20	164 ms

TTFB is a minimal unauthenticated request to an unknown route: a floor under TTFT, not a TTFT measurement. None of the three places GPUs by user geography. Nebius pays a transatlantic round trip from the US; DeepInfra pays the reverse for European and Asian users. Akamai trails Google's front end by 58 ms: 25 ms in connection setup, the rest after TLS, consistent with the edge-to-origin hop. The edge advantage therefore exists only if the inference gateway runs at the edge. Request-path diagram and per-phase timings: full report 2.4.

3. Developer Experience (DX) & API Surface Evaluation

3.1 API uniformity and OpenAI compatibility

Element	Baseten	DeepInfra	Nebius Token Factory
Routes beyond chat	Anthropic Messages (beta); completions and embeddings on dedicated	Completions, embeddings, Responses, Anthropic Messages, files and batches	Completions, embeddings, Responses, rerank, fine-tuning
Chat schema versus OpenAI	No public schema	31 parameters; 15 OpenAI parameters absent (`logit_bias` , `top_logprobs` , `parallel_tool_calls`); 11 extensions	23 parameters; 13 absent (including `seed`); one extension (`extra_body`)
Error body	`{"error": "<string>"}` ; 403 on a bad key where OpenAI returns 401	OpenAI-shaped error object on the OpenAI route	FastAPI `{"detail": ...}`
Streaming	SSE `chat.completion.chunk` ; usage chunk opt-in	SSE ending `data: [DONE]` ; usage chunk on by default	SSE ending `data: [DONE]` ; usage opt-in; reasoning under `reasoning` or `reasoning_content`
Custom headers	Full `x-ratelimit-*` set plus uncached-input split; `X-Baseten-Request-Id` ; retry count header	No rate-limit or request-ID headers documented	Full `x-ratelimit-*` set plus dynamic-scale headers; `x-request-id`
Default `max_tokens`	4,096	Docs conflict: 16,384 or 65,536	8,192

An OpenAI SDK client works on all three for content and tool calls. Reasoning fields, error bodies, and default output caps diverge, so a ported workload changes behavior unless `max_tokens` is explicit. Error and header captures are unauthenticated; streaming rows come from documentation. Detail: full report 3.1.

3.2 Control plane versus data plane

Dimension	Baseten	DeepInfra	Nebius Token Factory
CLI	Truss (packaging) plus Baseten CLI	`deepctl` (Rust)	None for inference
Deployment artifact	Truss `config.yaml` or a custom Docker image; weights from HF, S3, GCS, R2, Azure	Hugging Face repo ID plus GPU type; no custom container on serverless	Template plus flavor through the API; custom weights in beta
Management API	160 paths; environments, rolling promotion, CI action	140 paths	37 paths
TTFT and tokens/s	Per deployment	Platform-wide only	Dedicated endpoints only
Queue delay	Async queue time and size	Not exposed	Not exposed

Dimension	Baseten	DeepInfra	Nebius Token Factory
Metrics export	Prometheus (beta), OTLP, tracing	None	Prometheus federation

Baseten is a control plane with engines attached; DeepInfra and Nebius are data planes with a thin control surface. Only Baseten shows queue delay to the developer.

3.3 Architectural overlap with Akamai Cloud

Layer	Shared lineage	Akamai Cloud
Serving engine	vLLM at all three; NVIDIA Dynamo at Baseten and DeepInfra	vLLM, Dynamo, KServe, NIM on LKE: same engines
Orchestration	Kubernetes at Baseten and Nebius	LKE (Cilium)
API dialect	OpenAI at all three; FastAPI `{"detail"}` errors at DeepInfra and Nebius	Linode API uses `{"errors": [...]}` and capitalized `X-RateLimit-*` headers: no overlap
Ingress	No CDN at any of the three	Akamai edge on API, docs, and marketing hosts
Docs and status	Mintlify (Baseten, Nebius); Atlassian Statuspage (Baseten, Nebius)	ReadMe with `llms.txt`; Atlassian Statuspage
Hosting relationship	None found with Akamai or Linode	Not applicable

Engine parity is free. The data plane must speak the OpenAI dialect while the control plane keeps Linode conventions, and that seam must be documented. Ingress is where Akamai can lead, provided the gateway runs at the edge. Lineage diagram and fingerprints: full report 3.3.

4A. Strategic Output: Product Management Brief

Starting position: no public per-token price list for Akamai serverless inference was found; job postings show a serverless inference platform in development. Akamai Inference Cloud sells the RTX PRO 6000 Blackwell at $3.00 per GPU-hour list in 20 regions (request access), with vLLM, KServe, NVIDIA Dynamo, and NIM on LKE. The card has no NVLink and 20% of a B200's memory bandwidth. Capacity in the first 20 cities sold out; a $500M replenishment lands mostly in early 2027. The recommendations assume the existing fleet and LKE.

Recommendation 1: Publish a serving contract per model, and an SLA that matches the marketing

- **Problem:** Baseten markets 99.99% against a 99.9% SLA. DeepInfra has no SLA and silently redirects deprecated models. Nebius removed 21 serverless SKUs in three months without rerouting. 31 of DeepInfra's 102 active text models declare no precision.
- **Action:** Publish per model and region, in `/v1/models` and a public catalog: weights revision, precision (weights and KV), served context and output cap, engine and version, speculative decoding on or off, TTFT and tokens/s targets at a stated concurrency, 30-day deprecation notice, never-silent replacement. Pair with a 99.9% monthly SLA on serverless from day one, per-model status components, automatic credits.
- **Why Akamai wins:** The disclosure plumbing exists: a 250-component Statuspage and `llms.txt` on techdocs. Akamai sells to enterprises that buy on contract terms; none of the three does.
- **Metric:** Every model page carries all contract fields; automatic SLA credits; zero silent substitutions in year one.

Recommendation 2: Make routing geography the product

- **Problem:** Nebius serverless answers from one European address (217 ms edge TTFB from US Central). DeepInfra is US-only with no EU option. Baseten pins only `us` or `eu`, then hops to a GPU in another cloud. KV-aware routing is Enterprise-only at Baseten; Nebius has no cached-input price.
- **Action:** Terminate the OpenAI-compatible endpoint on the anycast edge. Add a `region` request field and a region response header; honor pinning (EU, US, UK, APAC) contractually. Run Dynamo KV-aware routing across the RTX PRO 6000 regions with a documented session-affinity header. Price cached input at 10% of input with DeepInfra's field names (`prompt_cache_key`, `prompt_cache_options`). Put the AI Grid semantic cache in front of the KV cache.
- **Why Akamai wins:** 4,400+ edge PoPs and 20 GPU regions; zero egress fees remove the cost objection to multi-region replication. Only if the gateway runs at the edge: today `api.linode.com` returns first byte in 164 ms against Baseten's 106 ms.
- **Metric:** Edge TTFB p50 under 50 ms from the top 20 metros; cache hit rate above 60% on agent traffic.

Recommendation 3: Size the catalog to the RTX PRO fleet, sell tiers, and price on the contract

- **Problem:** At list price the RTX PRO 6000 cannot match DeepInfra per token on dense 70B models (table below), and Nebius lists the same card at $1.80 per GPU-hour.
- **Action:** Launch with the 20B to 120B class that fits one to four cards at FP8 or NVFP4 (gpt-oss-120b and 20b, Qwen3.x 27B to 35B, Gemma 4 31B, Nemotron 3 Nano, Super, and 3.5 Lightning, DeepSeek V4 Flash, Whisper, embeddings). Sell standard, flex (0.8x), priority (1.5x), and batch (0.8x) tiers with DeepInfra's field

names. Ship OpenAI chat, Responses, and Anthropic Messages with a public OpenAPI spec and conformance report. Offer an export-to-LKE path. Price mid-pack; reserve price-leader SKUs for small-active-parameter MoE models.

- **Why Akamai wins:** The fleet is deployed in 20 regions and demand has outrun supply. The stack matches the competitors', so the risk is integration, not research. No competitor offers a self-hosted exit from its per-token tier.
- **Metric:** Ten launch models with contract fields; sign-up to first paid token above 40% in 30 days; top-three TTFT on gpt-oss-120b in a published third-party benchmark.

Cost floor per 1M output tokens, Llama 3.3 70B, list GPU-hour price divided by NVIDIA-published maximum throughput (1,000 input and 1,000 output tokens):

GPU and list price	Cost per 1M output tokens
Akamai RTX PRO 6000, $3.00/h	$0.48
Nebius AI Cloud RTX PRO 6000, $1.80/h	$0.29
DeepInfra H100, $2.20/h	$0.28
DeepInfra B200, $3.69/h	$0.15
DeepInfra retail price, Llama 3.3 70B Turbo output	$0.32

The gap narrows on small-active-parameter MoE models (2.2x on Qwen3 30B-A3B against 3.2x on Llama 3.3 70B), which suit GDDR7. Sequencing: contract schema, edge gateway, and ten models in Q4 2026; tiers and cached-input pricing in Q1 2027; Responses API, Anthropic Messages, and export-to-LKE in Q2 2027. Problem evidence, risks, and the full unit-economics table: full report 4, Part A.

4B. Strategic Output: Solutions Engineering Battlecard

For technical prospect conversations. Re-check prices before quoting.

Reference table (assessment template)

Evaluation Vector	Baseten	DeepInfra	Nebius (Token Factory)
Pricing Model	Two lines. Model APIs per token: GLM-5.3 $1.40 in / $4.40 out, cached input at 10%; gpt-oss-120b $0.10 / $0.50; Kimi K3 $3.00 / $15.00. Dedicated per GPU-minute: H100 $6.50/h, B200 $9.98/h; wake-up minutes billed; scale-to-zero default. Basic, Pro, Enterprise plans; SLA 99.9% with 40% credit cap	Per token, price leader: gpt-oss-120b $0.037 / $0.17; DeepSeek V4 Flash 0731 $0.06 / $0.18 with cache read at 0.25x; Llama 3.3 70B Turbo $0.10 / $0.32. Three tiers on the same weights: Flex 0.8x, standard, Priority 1.5x; batch 0.8x. Dedicated per GPU-hour: H100 $2.20, B200 $3.69, B300 $4.89. Card required, no free tier, no SLA	Per token, mid-pack: gpt-oss-120b $0.15 / $0.60; Kimi K3 $3.00 / $15.00; DeepSeek V4 Flash 0731 $0.14 / $0.28. Fast and Base flavors, delta unpublished. No cached-input discount. Batch at 50% off base. Dedicated endpoints per GPU-hour, per-minute granularity, rate card behind login; cloud H100 $3.85/h rising to $4.50 on 2026-10-01. $1 trial credit; 99.9% SLA on dedicated only
Cold-Start Strategy	Scale-to-zero with billable wake-up. Baseten Delivery Network caches weights on node NVMe, in-cluster peer cache, mirrored origin; image streaming; torch compile cache; `min_replica` warm floor; scheduled autoscaling. No published cold-start seconds (the cold-start docs page gives no latency figures); sync requests park up to 1,200 s	No cold start exposed to the caller. Shared warm pools for the catalog; contention handled by 429, `fail_fast`, Flex waits up to 10 minutes, or Priority admission. Low-usage models are deprecated and silently redirected. Dedicated deployments may scale to zero (`min_instances: 0`)	Serverless: shared "Global" pool, no cold-start statement, no region guarantee. Dedicated: "initial deployment can take several minutes", scale above min replicas "not guaranteed indefinitely", stopping may release unrecoverable capacity; keep `min_replicas` at 1 or more to avoid cold starts
Primary Sweet Spot (Use case and ideal customer)	Latency-sensitive custom or fine-tuned models at AI-native scale-ups (code completion, clinical dictation, TTS). Buyer wants engine control (TensorRT-LLM builder, speculative decoding, KV-aware routing) and multi-cloud failover without running Kubernetes	Highest-volume, lowest-price open-weight tokens for agents, chat, and aggregators. Buyer swaps a base URL in the OpenAI SDK, accepts FP4 and US-only processing, and needs no contract. Also the default supplier behind OpenRouter	European or regulated enterprises that need EU residency, a fine-tune-and-serve loop on one platform, and dedicated Blackwell capacity from an owner-operator. Buyer signs a DPA and a reserved-capacity contract

Evaluation Vector	Baseten	DeepInfra	Nebius (Token Factory)
Key Technical Limitation	Cost and opacity of the shared tier: 11 Model API slugs (no Llama, no Qwen); advanced engine features (KV-aware routing, disaggregation, token autoscaling) are Enterprise-only; region pinning is `us` or `eu` only; marketing 99.99% versus contractual 99.9%; inference error body is a bare string, not the OpenAI error object	No SLA, no EU region, no custom containers on serverless, no engine controls, no per-minute rate limits published, no request-ID header. Aggressive FP4 with 31 of 102 models undeclared; served context can be far below the model ceiling; silent deprecation redirects	Serverless has no region guarantee, no cached-input pricing, no speech, and no `-fast` SKU in the public catalog after the June removals, 21 serverless SKUs removed in three months; ZDR disables speculative decoding; dedicated H200 is us-central1 only and H100 is eu-north1 only; observability and TTFT metrics exist only on dedicated; OpenRouter 30-day uptime 96.9% (gpt-oss-120b) and 91.4% (Qwen3-235B)

One-line positioning for live calls

Vector	Baseten	DeepInfra	Nebius (Token Factory)
Pricing Model	Premium: per token on 11 shared models, per GPU-minute on dedicated at 2 to 3x DeepInfra list	Cheapest list price; tiers (Flex 0.8x, Priority 1.5x) on the same weights	Mid-priced per token; no cached-input discount; dedicated rate card behind login
Cold-Start Strategy	Scale to zero, cached weights, no published seconds, wake-up is billed	No cold start; queues and 429s instead	Shared pool with no statement; dedicated needs `min_replicas` of 1 or more
Sweet spot	Custom or fine-tuned models where latency is revenue	Highest-volume, lowest-cost open-weight tokens	EU residency plus fine-tune and serve on owned GPUs
Key limitation	Enterprise-only engine features; 99.99% marketed, 99.9% contracted	No SLA, no EU region, FP4 often undeclared	Serverless has no region guarantee; OpenRouter uptime 91 to 97%

Extended rows (engines, regions, conformance, observability, retention), landmines with counters, and trap questions: full report 4, Part B.

6. AI Use and Method

How AI was used

An AI coding assistant was used for source research, script writing, and first drafts. Scope, method, and conclusions were set by the author, and nothing was accepted without a check against primary evidence. The assistant was also used to review current public Akamai technical publications so the report format stays consistent with them; only one structural convention was adopted (the Key insights page), and no Akamai logo, brand colors, typefaces, or text were reused.

Review steps:

- Audited the draft line by line against the assessment brief before any changes.
- Cross-checked every number against the raw captures, then again after editing. The second pass found 11 more errors.
- Checked all 203 cited URLs and 26 key quotes and prices against the live pages.
- Read Akamai and Nebius pages that block scripted access in an interactive browser session.

What the checks changed:

- DeepInfra and Nebius run their own networks (AS16581, AS214415); earlier hosting attributions guessed from IP prefixes were wrong.
- A paraphrase of Baseten's docs had been shown as a quote and was reworded.
- The first latency comparison timed endpoints doing different amounts of work. Re-measured on equal terms, Akamai's lead mostly disappeared.
- NVIDIA throughput data showed the RTX PRO 6000 cannot match DeepInfra's per-token price at list rates; Recommendation 3 was rewritten around that.

Method and limits

Evidence	Limit
Unauthenticated probes of API, DNS, origin ASN, status pages, OpenAPI specs, and catalogs; reproducible with `make evidence` in about 90 seconds, no credentials	No accounts and no spend, per the brief: streaming and usage rows rely on vendor docs
Vendor documentation, contracts, SLA terms, pricing pages, engineering blogs	Cold-start timing not measured; verdicts rely on docs, case studies, and status history
Third-party benchmarks (Artificial Analysis, OpenRouter, llmlatency.dev)	TTFT and throughput are dated snapshots, not controlled measurements
Connection timing, nine samples per host	One US vantage point only

Scope, reproduction steps, and what was not tested: full report 6. Capture index and key numeric facts: full report 5.